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THE EARTH IS THE LORD'S

★ *Shri Vinoba Bhave*
and the land ★

by
MARJORIE SYKES

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Sixpence

VINOBA BHAVE

“ Since the assassination of the Mahatma, there was no pre-eminent figure who appealed to the religious instinct in most Indians as Mr. Nehru appeals in a political sense. The tremendous enthusiasm shown for Mr. Bhave's unique mission may indicate that such a personage has been found.”

New York Times,
13. xi. 51.

“ A new name is being heard increasingly in news from India. It is Vinoba Bhave, a disciple of Gandhi.”

Manchester Guardian,
2. v. 52.

“ My Man of the Year is a far humbler man. . . . He is Acharya Vinoba Bhave. And he is definitely, at least within our own frontiers, the Man of the Year (1951).”

The Overseas Hindustan Times,
3. i. 52.

“ What stands out is the remarkable fact that in response to the appeals of this frail, small-voiced ascetic, landowners of Telengana began to part with land. History does not provide many comparable examples where people may have given away their lands willingly, voluntarily and cheerfully for distribution among the poor.”

Hindustan Times,
19. vi. 51.

Cover Layout by HAROLD SUMPTION

THE EARTH IS THE LORD'S

SHRI VINOBA BHAVE AND THE LAND

THE Bhoomi-dana Yagna, or Land Gift Mission as it is referred to in English, initiated by Shri Vinoba Bhave in April, 1951, is now receiving a good deal of publicity in various parts of the world. It is important that it should be properly understood. It has, as I believe, affinities with those movements of thought and action in the west which seek to recall mankind to health of body and sanity of mind, to wholeness of living, contentment and peace, through a right relationship with the soil from whose creative fertility we are all fed. Vinoba Bhave's work, his aims, attitudes and methods, should be of the profoundest interest to all those who are working for the coming of earth of the kingdom of brotherly love, peace and goodwill.

Vinoba Bhave, now about fifty-six years old, has been a follower of Mahatma Gandhi for more than thirty years, and when still a young man established a small "Ashram" at Wardha as a centre of constructive national service. This Ashram was later moved to the village of Paunary, about seven miles from Wardha, where it still remains. Even among national workers, however, Vinoba's name was almost unknown until 1940. Then Mahatma Gandhi selected him to initiate the "individual Satya-graha" against India's participation in the second world war, because of the consistency of his life with the principles of non-violence. Shri Vinoba describes himself as "a humble devotee of God who regards the service of the poor as the way to the attainment of the highest goal of life". His service of the poor in Paunary expresses itself in persistent teaching and demonstration of the value of the proper scavenging of village streets, in a deep interest in village "Basic Education" of which he is one of the great inspirers, and in the experimental work of the Ashram farm. Vinoba and his fellow-worker sare trying to find out how far and in what conditions they can eliminate from their daily dealings the use of money. They grow their food and cotton and weave their cloth, and do their utmost to obtain such necessities as they cannot themselves produce by local barter, not by money purchase.

This last feature will probably strike many westerners as quite unrealistic, even as a form of escapism. Before they pass judgment, however, they should try to understand the whole outlook of Shri Vinoba of which this is one part, and to see how it is related to his present mission. One thing at least should be clear—that his ideas are not the outcome of mere sentimental theorizing untested by living; they are the outcome of years of hard, unpublicized labour. His words carry the authority of experience.

The fundamental purpose of all Vinoba's work is to contribute to the building up of a truly humane and brotherly way of life, primarily in and for India, but with a full recognition that the principles underlying it are universal in their application, and with the hope that a response will be found all over the world. The programme is based on Gandhiji's conception of "Truth and non-violence" and is an interpretation of his well-known "Constructive programme" carried out as one integrated whole. Vinoba calls this ideal "Sarvodaya" ("Sarva"—all; "Udaya"—rising). The measure of the well-being of any community, by this standard, is the extent to which *all* its members (not a few favoured ones only) *rise together* to complete joyful fulfilment. After Gandhi's death in 1948 Vinoba took the lead in the formation of the Sarvodaya Samaj, a fellowship whose membership is open to all who are prepared to devote themselves to the ideal and programme of Sarvodaya. The Sarvodaya Samaj reflects in its constitution the bent of Shri Vinoba's mind, and the English word "fellowship" suggests its nature much better than the more formal "Society". It has no organization, no subscription, no burden of administrative routine. It is characteristically Indian in deriving its inspiration from a living Guru (Shri Vinoba himself) and in the developing custom of an annual Sammelan—a "coming together", a "gathering" (conference is too formal and limited a word)—to which multitudes of workers come every year for renewal of vision and refreshment of spirit.

The Sammelan of 1951 was held in April, at a village called Sivaramapalli in Hyderabad State. Vinoba's friends pleaded that he should be there in person, but to go by train (an easy overnight journey from Wardha) would mean using money, which he did not want to do. Vinoba went, but he went on foot. He set out from Paunar early in March, and walked with a small group of followers from village to village, covering a few miles every day, and every day learning more of the grave problems that confronted the people. He would urge the wealthy farmers and landowners to revive the old and righteous custom of paying their labourers at least their basic wage in kind, in grain and cotton and cloth, instead of leaving

them at the mercy of a fluctuating money market. The misery of the landless poor was brought home to him afresh. After the Sammelan was over he went on foot through the Telengana districts of Hyderabad where communist unrest had been most marked, seeking to understand the communists and the nature of their appeal. On April 18 he was met by a party of Harijans (the so-called low-caste untouchables, nearly all of whom are landless labourers) who pleaded with him for land. Vinoba assembled the people of the village to which they belonged, and appealed to them to give to their landless fellow-villagers the land they needed to support themselves. The land was given.

This incident was the spark that kindled in Vinoba's mind the idea of *Bhoomi-dana Yagna*. From that day forward he began to put it before every village audience he met. "If you have four sons and a fifth is born, you will certainly give him his share," he would say. "Treat me as your fifth son, and give me my share. Give freely and willingly for the sake of *Daridra-narayan*—God revealed in the poor and needy."

The people responded. When Vinoba returned to Paunar two months later he had received about 12,000 acres of land in trust for the landless poor.

A short time after this, Shri Vinoba was invited by the Prime Minister to place his views on the social and economic development of the country before the National Planning Commission at Delhi. He started from Paunar in the second week of September, at the end of the rains, walking through Madhya Pradesh and parts of Vindhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh, and reached Delhi two months later, in the second week of November. Doubts had been expressed about whether gifts of land like those received in Hyderabad would be forthcoming in other places where the special conditions of the Telengana country did not exist. The matter was now put to the test. During the two months' tramp to Delhi, Vinoba received 18,000 acres of land. He was convinced that the common people everywhere were ready to respond to his appeal and to co-operate in a non-violent revolution in the ideology of land ownership.

Vinobaji therefore drew up, in consultation with Sarvodaya workers in U.P., a comprehensive plan for Land gifts throughout the whole state. The aim is to settle at least one landless family in every village of U.P. At the rate of 5 acres for a family in each of about 100,000 villages, this means asking for half a million acres of land in that state alone. In spite of the excitement and distractions of the state and central Government election which immediately followed, about 100,000 acres had been collected in U.P., before

the end of April. The workers of the Sarvodaya Samaj, who met Vinobaji at the 1952 annual "Sammelan" near Benares early in April, have undertaken to obtain $2\frac{1}{2}$ million acres during the next two years in the various states of India. Reports are now coming in from widely-separated areas of the first of these donations, and statistics are being published in the Hindi monthly *Sarvodaya*, which Vinoba makes the vehicle of his idea as Gandhiji used "Young India" and "Harijan". Vinoba has stated his own final target as 50 million acres; one acre in every six of India's cultivated land.

Every gift deed is legally executed and signed by donor and witnesses. The gifts are not mere verbal promises which may never be redeemed, but legally binding undertakings. When the time comes for distribution of the land obtained, the procedure which is already being followed in Hyderabad State is likely to be adopted in other areas with minor modifications. The Tahsildar of the area first ascertains whether any arrears of land revenue or other amounts are due to Government on the land in question. When the inquiry is completed a Committee, appointed by Vinobaji himself, selects the persons to whom the land shall be granted. The Hyderabad committee has decided to allot one acre of "wet" land to each family, or a *maximum* of six acres of "dry" land. In choosing the recipients, the committee gathers the whole village concerned together and asks them to name the most suitable families among the landless. Care is taken to allocate the land to those who have no other means of support, and who have the skill and perseverance to make the best use of it; other things being equal, preference is given to Harijans and other backward communities, and bullocks, seed and implements for cultivation are made available. The committee members are accompanied to the village by revenue Officials who complete the work of registration and the legal formalities. It is clear that very much depends upon the integrity and wisdom of the distribution committees, and their members are chosen by Vinoba with very great care. A second committee with a different personnel takes charge of the reception of gifts in each state.

"My aim," said Vinoba in Delhi last November, "is to bring about a three-fold revolution. Firstly, I want a change in people's hearts; secondly, I want to create a change in the lives; and thirdly, I want to change the social structure." In an appeal to the nation issued on 28 April, 1952, he gives three reasons for his faith that this work is, as Quakers would say, in right ordering—"It is in tune with the cultural traditions of India. It contains in it the seeds of economic and social revolution. And lastly, it can help in the establishment of peace in the world." The external

activities, achievements and plans described above should be considered in conjunction with these aims and ideals and with the methods which Vinoba uses in his daily work.

The writer had the privilege of accompanying Shri Vinoba for a few days during the later stages of his pilgrimage to Delhi, at the end of October, 1951. By then, trial and experiment had established the most practical daily routine. Quietly, soon after three each morning, the little party gets up; we roll up our beddings, with spare clothes and oddments of kit inside, and pack them in the cart (sometimes, on the main roads, it is a jeep) which the villagers have provided to carry them to the next halt. On the stroke of four Vinoba gives the signal, and the group of perhaps ten or a dozen people steps out of the sleeping village on to the empty, starlit road. As we go we recite the common morning prayer; after that each walks in silence, in meditation if he so wishes. After about an hour the silence is broken; people begin to talk quietly, and Vinoba, talking informally from the great stores of his knowledge, is a joy to listen to. The people of villages by the roadside gather together while it is still dark to watch him pass; they sing and offer garlands, and Vinoba greets them, but does not stop; those who want to talk with him join the march. Dawn breaks, and soon after six, as the sun comes up, we sit down in some field by the roadside for breakfast—fifteen minutes allowed. By that time we are about eight miles from our last night's lodging; usually another six or eight miles lie ahead. By nine o'clock, sometimes earlier, the next halting place is reached; the people are eagerly waiting, and lead us to the shade of some tree in the centre of the village, or in some spacious farmhouse courtyard, where a carpet has been spread on a raised place from which Vinoba may speak to the crowd. Briefly he explains the day's programme; ample time is allowed for personal talks with individuals or small groups, a couple of hours at midday for food and rest. In the late afternoon the main meeting is held; there is a half-hour of silent spinning, followed by a discourse of usually about forty-five minutes; then comes the evening prayer. The meeting breaks up, to be followed by more personal talks, and by 7.30 or 8 p.m. all prepare for bed. No matter how small the village or how large the city where the halt takes place (for Vinoba does not avoid cities that lie on his path) one day, and one day only, is allocated to it. Only very occasionally he has spent two days in one place, where a "sammelan" of Sarvodaya workers has been called, as at Saugar in Mahakoshal and Mathura in Uttar Pradesh.

So Vinoba chooses the simplest, most personal way to give his message—the way of the wandering village teacher.

He walks—and one can almost hear the “efficient” westerner exclaiming in bewilderment against the waste of time and energy “which might otherwise be devoted to the work itself”. Hundreds of people, at a word from him, would place their cars at his disposal. But—for Vinoba’s purpose, walking is more efficient. It affords greatly-increased opportunities for meeting face to face and on terms of intimacy, with ordinary people on the roadside and in the field. The man with a problem or anxiety on his mind can drop into step as the little procession comes along the road, walk alongside Vinoba for a mile or two, and return home again with his need for advice or guidance met. There is no temptation in a walking tour to make the distance between stages inaccessiblely great: villagers who miss their chance of seeing or hearing him at one place can and do trudge after him to the next and are satisfied. There is leisure and scope for intercourse, both on the road and at the halting place, of which motor transport is by its nature destructive. In the campaign for a new society for Sarvodaya, whose very lifeblood is the freely-given loyalty of men, and which is as far removed as possible both from legalistic conceptions and from short-term opportunist politics, this leisured, intimate, informal meeting with ordinary people at their ordinary daily work, is of very great importance. And this quality of meeting is possible only to him who goes on foot along the village lanes. Walking is not a waste but an opportunity.

At a deeper level than this, walking is a symbol of the self-identification of the teacher with the poorest of the poor. It is a symbol of Sarvodaya itself. Those who are wholly committed to the ideal of “together-ness” will not seek or desire any convenience or comfort for themselves which is not equally available for all. In limiting his travel to what can be accomplished daily by his own legs, Vinoba is placing himself alongside the multitudes who must walk in all their lives, whether they will or no, because they have not the wherewithal to buy a ride. Labouring in the fields at Pauniar, and trudging the roads of Hyderabad or Uttar Pradesh, he speaks to the people as one of themselves.

But deeper still is the protest of his spirit against capitalistic finance. To use the train, or any form of motor transport, would mean being caught in the tentacles of the money economy whose workings he believes to be essentially hostile to the true welfare of the land, and of the men who draw their sustenance from the land. At the very centre of Vinoba’s teaching is this message of the true meaning of man’s relationship to the soil from which he springs. The message is weighed with all the force and sincerity of his own personal witness at Pauniar to a life of labour-subsistence, free from

the chains of money. In the proclamation of that message to the people he must remain free. The message itself is a profoundly religious one. Vinoba declares, and most sincerely believes, that he is "only an instrument in the hands of Him, the Lord of all ages", and that God Himself inspires his mission and prepares men's hearts to respond to it. Like the great Hebrew prophets, he stands before men with "Thus saith the Lord", and declares to them the will of God.

Like them, too, and like the great religious spirits who wrote the book of Deuteronomy and the 119th Psalm, he sees the will of God in the majestic social laws which enshrine man's insight into the nature of his relationship with the universe, with the soil which sustains him and with all living creatures and all fellowmen who share with him his dependence on the earth and the sun. Keep the divine commandment, says Deuteronomy, and "blessed shall be the fruit of thy body, the fruit of thy ground, and the fruit of thy cattle". Vinoba, quoting the wisdom of ancient Hindu law, says the same thing. "The earth is the Lord's, and the fulness thereof," declared the Psalmist. The soil, like the sun and rain which nourish it, is a gift and a trust from God, declares Vinoba. Its mysterious creative powers, its riches, are for all mankind—nay more, they are for all life, of which men are a part. The soil can never be rightly regarded as a personal possession, to be used or misused for individual profit or according to one's personal whim. We sin against *Dharma*, against the very nature of things, if we take for private profit what God has given for our common sustenance. "Constant is Earth the Mother, whom never may any man take for himself alone," wrote the Hindu poet Maitheli Saran Gupta as the refrain of his poem on Vinoba's mission, and Vinoba quotes him with approval. This is the teaching of the scripture, he reminds us—of the Koran no less than of the Gita. And we may add, of the Bible no less than of the Koran. The land belongs to God, like sun and air and water.

So Vinoba appeals to all that is best and noblest in the traditional teaching of Hindu and Muslim alike, and Hindu and Muslim alike respond. The appeal is, as he claims, in line with the cultural traditions of India; the tradition of religious insight and devotion is not dead, and Vinoba awakens it to new life. Like all true teachers, he seizes on some immediate interest of the group before him, and with a word uncovers its spiritual depths. At the Diwali festival, when the householder prays to Lakshmi for wealth and welfare in the coming year, he speaks of the secret of true wealth and welfare. As we enter Mathura, associated with the birth and childhood of the Lord Krishna, he expounds the teaching of

Krishna in the Gita, telling his audience that true prosperity and peace is to be found only in obedience to the eternal law of God. "Of what use is it to live in the earthly birthplace of Lord Krishna," he asks, "unless the Eternal Krishna is born and dwells in your hearts?"

Let, therefore, the land be shared, not grudgingly but willingly, lovingly, gladly. Let the village be one family, in which it is the concern of all that each man's needs should be met. Let those who have give to those who have not, so that all may have the means to earn their bread by their labour. This is the meaning of the *Bhoomi-dana* Yagna, the sacred gift of land. Such a gift must be the token of brotherly affection, the result of persuasion, not of force. Let no one think that the *bhoomi-dana* (land-gift) is a humiliating charity. The true meaning of the word *dana* (gift) is equitable division, and it is in that sense—to connote God's justice for God's people in God's world—that Vinoba uses it. "The receiver of the land will not get his bread for nothing. He will have to work upon the land, improve it, and wet it with his own sweat before he can get his bread from it. He has no reason to feel humiliated. So we are giving him his own share and not bestowing charity upon him."

Vinoba's sense of a divine commissioning gives him not only authority but also serenity of spirit. Where God has inspired the message, He will surely raise up those who will hear and respond—if not to-day, then to-morrow; if not this year, then next year. He does not fret about apparent slowness of response, nor does he attempt to provide beforehand solutions for all the theoretical problems that might arise if and when he succeeds. "The main thing is that one should do one's duty. Fire merely burns; it does not worry whether anyone puts a pot on it, fills it with water and puts rice in it to make a meal. It burns and that is the limit of its duty. It is for others to do theirs—my purpose is to create a change in everyone's heart. I cannot predict when it will come. I only tell the people my ideas and accept land if they offer it."

I have compared Vinoba to the great Hebrew prophets, but in one respect he has learned from teachers greater than they, from the Buddha and the Christ, by whose methods alone, he says, the change of heart that he seeks can be brought about. Unlike Isaiah or Micah, who were concerned like him with those that "join field to field until there is no more room", he does not cry "Woe" upon the human instrument of our present injustices. He works not through denunciation, but "through persuasion and affection". "The jagirdars, big landowners and Zamindars are our own brethren. Their interests should not be ignored." "If

I am the agent both of the rich and of the poor, I shall be glad, for that is the aim of Sarvodaya.” “I shall praise people, never denounce or say harsh things against them. Every one has his good points. I am convinced that people have great qualities. They have to be discovered and appreciated.” Thus Vinoba is working, as he says, to create the atmosphere necessary for an equitable and non-violent redistribution of the land, both among the “haves” and among the “have-nots”. He refuses to regard the former as *ipso facto* the enemies of the people.

Because of this, he has been accused of being a friend of the *status quo*; it is said that the object of his work is to “stave off revolution” by concessions. He replies with spirit that his aim is not to prevent but to create a revolution—a social and economic revolution of the most profound and far-reaching character, which will change the whole social structure of the country. Without a revolution in the land system, there can be neither peace nor prosperity. Without the overthrow of the present social order by a new one based on equality and co-operation, there can be no salvation for mankind.

Vinoba then is a revolutionary; but he is a non-violent revolutionary. He is convinced that peaceful methods *can* succeed, that the means determine the ends, and that murder and violence can never bring lasting justice and peace. Yet he sees clearly that unless land is equitably redistributed either through voluntary gifts or through acceptable legislation, bloody revolution will be inevitable. It is this reading of the signs of the times which brings to his work that note of urgency which is present in so many of the world’s prophets.

This raises the question of Vinoba’s attitude to land reform legislation. Some have thought that he relies entirely on persuasion for the solution of the land problems of India, and that land reform legislation is outside his range of vision. This is not so. The reform of the land laws is not his work—it is being tackled by others. His work, as he sees it, is to create the atmosphere of public opinion in which alone the laws can be successfully changed. The majority, even the majority of landowners, should be mentally prepared for change; then the opposition of a small minority will not matter. “I say this,” he writes, “because Communists also want legislation. They begin with murder and want to bring in legislation at the end. My plan also envisages legislation at the end, but I want to begin with pity and kindness. When every heart begins to feel that the present order is unjust, when pity is created and a proper understanding of the situation brought about, legislation can come in at the end. This is the non-violent way.”

The other main charge levelled against Shri Vinoba is that his mission, if it succeeds, will encourage an uneconomic fragmentation of holdings. There are two replies to this. Vinoba himself replies that his campaign, in so far as it truly succeeds, will generate a new spirit of brotherly concern for the common welfare which will ensure that all the land of the village, however held, is used fully and for the common lasting good of all. The second answer is that the contention that large-scale commercial farming of large estates is more remunerative, in terms of production, than the intensive cultivation of small family holdings, is a hypothesis still unproved. Moreover, it is too often based on the unspoken assumptions of capitalist farming, "which values the land as a commodity producing money, not as the creator of life and health."

Vinoba's attitude to the soil is altogether different from this. He never lets a day pass without urging upon his hearers in some way or other, the sacred duty and human necessity of regular and physical labour. Labour on the land was the foundation of Indian civilization; all castes, whatever their specialized functions might be, were farmers alike; King Janak drove the plough. Contact with the living soil and the life-giving sunlight is the secret of health; how many of our modern diseases spring from the lack of healthy vigorous physical work, from a serious unbalance of our modern plan of life?

Vinoba's work and message is shaped and pointed by its Indian setting; but at this point, when he speaks of the basic, inescapable dependence of human life and health on a proper relationship with the creative soil, his thought finds echoes again and again in modern western thought. The phrase about capitalist farming quoted above was from G. T. Wrench's "Reconstruction by Way of the Soil". Man's task and privilege, Wrench writes, is to become a partner in the creative power of the soil, through whole-hearted acceptance of the bounds set him, as a creature of the Creator, by the essential nature of life and death. Let him realize that farming is more than "scientific agriculture": it is a way of life itself, a way of health and wholeness. Let him realize that the natural partnership with the soil is that of the family; that the service of the soil by which we live is rightly given in the form of family farming, in the meticulous, loving, ceaseless care of the small cultivator for his little piece of land.

How very remote from the family farm and the life of the fields is the kind of life lived by most of those who are likely to read this essay, the writer is keenly aware. Vinoba's work has an immediate relevance to the situation of India to-day; it is possible for large numbers to take direct action at once in response to his appeal, and

the cumulative effect may be enormous. In lands where farming has long ceased to be a way of life for any but a small minority, and has become over large areas a form of commercial enterprise, he may almost seem to speak as from another planet. Yet in face of our desperate unhappiness and unrest, and of the fears and anxieties that haunt our modern civilization, it may well be that Vinoba and those western sociologists whose thoughts run parallel to his have a message to which we, too, should listen. Must we always assume that it is "impossible" to "go back"? If we are "off the track" of health and sanity because we have ignored the fundamental nature and conditions of life on earth, then surely the sooner we begin to get back to it the better.

QUOTATIONS FROM VINOBA BHAVE

“ My mission is to create a proper atmosphere for economic reforms. I have formed no organization to propagate my views. People who accept my ideas themselves become its preachers.”

“ My aim is to bring about a threefold revolution. Firstly, I want a change in people's hearts; secondly, I want to create a change in their lives; and thirdly, I want to change the social structure. Nothing can be achieved through pressure or force. If force is to be used, I am not required. My feeble hands would not be of any use.”

“ Thus there are two charges against me. Some say that I am a supporter of the old system. Others say I open the way for Communists to take charge. The fact that opposite charges are made against me shows that my work is on the right lines.”

“ People want a revolutionary programme, and think that a revolution cannot be wrought without bloodshed. Let me tell you, I cannot accept their contention. Those who think that a revolution cannot be wrought without bloodshed are not revolutionists at all.”

“ The Communists may still feel unconvinced and dub me a simpleton. But let me tell them that I know my trade. Let there be an atmosphere first, in however small a measure, the atmosphere, that this type of voluntary giving is to the good of the community, of the rich as well as the poor. Then I shall take the next step and move for necessary legislation. I am not going to wait indefinitely. But there must be, as a precedent, a change in the atmosphere and a change in the mentality of the people in favour of legislation. Then will be the time for legislation and the people will welcome it.”

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